

Married to Another

In Romans 7, we have been studying the Jew and the condition Israel was in when the law was given.

The Lord spoke that in His Word we will find the things we are looking for and truly desire. When His Word operates in faith and power, the things that should not be there are pulled down, strongholds are destroyed, and His peace replaces them. That peace surpasses all understanding.

His perfect love casts out fear. He that has fear has torment and has not been perfected by His love. Walk in His Spirit and allow Him to do these works in you, and you will see that what you have heard about peace is true. You can be free from torment and fear.

The Jewish community in Rome had difficulty understanding how Gentiles who had never kept the law could suddenly enter into the same inheritance. Paul answers that the law did not save Israel. By the law was the knowledge of sin.

Romans says it is not the outward Jew who inherits the promise, nor the outward circumcision. The true Jew is one inwardly, circumcised in the spirit: the old man cut away and replaced with the new.

God singled out Israel as a client nation to receive His commandments and work His altars. He gave them the law knowing they could not keep it, because they were spiritually dead. He used it as a standard and schoolmaster to reveal sin.

Romans 3 says:

"What things soever the law saith,
it saith to them who are under the law:
that every mouth may be stopped,
and all the world may become guilty before God."

The law stopped every mouth because neither Jew nor Gentile could meet its standard. God declared both under sin so He could have mercy on all.

Romans 7:1-4 says:

"Know ye not, brethren,
(for I speak to them that know the law,) how that the law hath dominion over a man as long as he liveth? For the woman which hath an husband is bound by the law to her husband so long as he liveth; but if the husband be dead, she is loosed from the law of her husband."

Paul is speaking to those who know the law, the Jewish community. Israel was married to God by the law. The part of the law that married them to God was the commandments: do not commit adultery, do not bear false witness, do not commit idolatry.

Those commandments described the new nature, but the Jew was spiritually dead and could not keep them. That created the dilemma.

Paul concludes:

"Wherefore, my brethren, ye also are become dead to the law by the body of Christ; that ye should be married to another, even to him who is raised from the dead, that we should bring forth fruit unto God."

The old man died with Christ. That death freed the Jew from the law to be married to another, even to the risen Christ. That union brings forth fruit unto God, the born-again spirit.

Romans 7:5 says:

"For when we were in the flesh, the motions of sins, which were by the law, did work in our members to bring forth fruit unto death."

"In the flesh" here describes the spiritually dead man under the law. The motions of sin were sin stirred into action by the commandment.

A spiritually dead man does not know he is spiritually dead. If you are born with one nature, how do you know there is anything else until someone tells you? The law came and told him to stop being what he was, and that is when the nature was exposed.

The motions of sin did not kill the Jew; he was already spiritually dead. They brought forth fruit unto the death that was already in him. Later in Romans 7, Paul says, "The good that I would do, I do not; and what I would not, that I do."

The law set sin into motion against his will.

Scripture says:

"What man knoweth the things of a man,
save the spirit of man which is in him?
even so the things of God knoweth no man,
but the Spirit of God."

When I was spiritually dead, I had no capacity to know outside the spiritual death reigning in my spirit. I could only know the things of man.

But when I was born again, I received the spirit that is of God, the new nature. Now my spirit can search God because I have a nature that can know Him.

Romans 8 says there is therefore now no condemnation to those in Christ Jesus, who walk not after the flesh but after the spirit. Those condemning sentences under the law cannot be carried out in me anymore because I have been set free.

Luke 16:18 says:

"Whosoever putteth away his wife,
and marrieth another,
committeth adultery:
and whosoever marrieth her that is put away from her husband
committeth adultery."

This verse has no fornication clause. Other passages include that clause, but this one does not. If this verse is read as a standalone rule for every second marriage, it creates terrible bondage and confusion.

I have seen religious people use it to tell a newly saved couple with children that they had to divorce because it was their second marriage. That kind of teaching can wreck lives.

James says teachers receive greater condemnation, because a teacher's words can bridle the body of Christ like a bit in a horse's mouth. Poisonous words come from a poisonous reservoir. But words full of revelation can lead the body into victory.

When I meditated this passage, suspending it before the Lord and reading the surrounding chapter again and again, Romans 7 flashed before me. Then the meaning opened.

Luke 16:18 is not primarily about marriage in the church today. It is about the change of covenants.

Luke 16 begins:

"There was a certain rich man..."

Verse 19 also begins:

"There was a certain rich man..."

The verses between are connected. Jesus is teaching about stewardship, money, and masters.

Luke 16:13 says:

"No servant can serve two masters...
Ye cannot serve God and mammon."

The Pharisees, who were covetous, heard these things and derided Him. They heckled Him from the floor, accusing Him of heresy and of forsaking Moses and the law.

Jesus answers:

"The law and the prophets were until John:
since that time the kingdom of God is preached,
and every man presseth into it.
And it is easier for heaven and earth to pass,
than one tittle of the law to fail."

Then He says:

"Whosoever putteth away his wife,
and marrieth another,
committeth adultery."

He is saying, "You accuse Me of putting away the law, but heaven and earth will pass before one mark of the law fails. I cannot put away the law and marry another without adultery."

Israel was married to God through the law. God became a Man so He could become one with those under the law, die under its penalty, and free them.

When Jesus cried, "My God, My God, why hast Thou forsaken Me?" and died, the law died with Him. His death widowed Israel from the law and freed them to marry another, even Him who was raised from the dead.

If Israel stayed married to the law after being freed from it, that was spiritual adultery. If they married Him who rose from the dead, their fruit would be unto God, and they would be born again.

Jesus says you cannot serve God and mammon. There are two ways to serve mammon.

The first is obvious: chasing wealth until you forsake God, prayer, and His plan.

The second is more subtle. God may tell you to go win a nation, and you say, "I did not have the funds." Then money dictated what you would or would not do for God. You served mammon by its absence.

God has set you free from poverty so money will not dictate your obedience.

The Pharisees were covetous. Jesus said:

"Ye are they which justify yourselves before men;
but God knoweth your hearts:
for that which is highly esteemed among men
is abomination in the sight of God."

The rich man clothed in purple and fine linen and faring sumptuously was not condemned for wealth itself. He was condemned because his wealth was not sanctified to God, and he stepped over Lazarus at his gate.

The rich man would not even give Lazarus crumbs. When he died and was in torment, he begged for Lazarus to bring him water. Then he begged for Lazarus to warn his five brothers.

Abraham answered that they had Moses and the prophets. If they would not hear them, neither would they be persuaded though one rose from the dead.

The offense Jesus warns about in Luke 17 flows from this same teaching. Money has power to twist a man terribly. The love of money is the root of all kinds of evil. Mammon is listed as a rival master because it can dictate life.

The answer is simple and severe: my money is God's. If the medium of exchange collapses, my money is still in my faith, because it already belongs to Him.

Romans 7 and Luke 16 are saying the same thing.

Israel was married to God through the law. Jesus came as a Man under the law. He died, and the law died with Him, freeing Israel to be married to another.

Romans 7 says:

"Ye also are become dead to the law by the body of Christ;
that ye should be married to another,
even to him who is raised from the dead,
that we should bring forth fruit unto God."

The old marriage under law produced the motions of sin and fruit unto death. The new marriage to the risen Christ produces born-again life, newness of spirit, and fruit unto God.